Project Shield Our Elders

Brevard County, Florida

Scam safety guide

Pause. Verify. Protect.

A guide for checking unexpected calls, messages, pop-ups, and QR codes.

- ## Pause before responding

  If a caller or message asks you to act quickly, keep a secret, or help a relative in an unexpected emergency, end the conversation while you check the story.

- ## Check who is contacting you

  Call the number on your bank card or statement, or a saved family number, instead of using contact details in the message. Caller ID and familiar voices can be faked.

- ## Keep your information private

  Do not share passwords, one-time codes, bank details, Social Security or Medicare numbers with an unexpected caller, or let them control your device. Avoid requests for gift cards, crypto, wires, payment apps, or transfers to a “safe account.”

If you already paid or shared information

If money was sent, call the bank or payment company right away and ask about stopping or reversing it. For a shared password or code, contact the account provider; for device access, use another safe device and get trusted tech help.

Keep messages and receipts, and ask someone you trust for help. Report a scam at ReportFraud.ftc.gov or 1-866-966-7226 (Florida). Avoid anyone charging to recover your money.

Trusted contact _____

Phone _____

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Family scam safety

A guide for families and caregivers

Scams can happen to anyone. A shared plan helps your family check unexpected requests while keeping your loved one involved in decisions.

Make a plan together

- Choose a trusted person and a backup, save their phone numbers, and keep a paper copy near the phone. Agree to check unexpected requests for money before responding.
- With your loved one’s permission, help set up account alerts, unique passwords, and two-step sign-in. Discuss suspicious contacts calmly and include them in decisions.

Check family emergencies

- Choose a private phrase that is easy to remember and unrelated to public facts or account passwords. Keep it off social media and workshop forms.
- For an unexpected family emergency, ask for the phrase without hints, then call a saved family number. Verify even if the voice sounds familiar or the phrase is correct, and change the phrase if it is exposed.

If money or information was shared

- If money was sent, contact the bank, card issuer, or payment service as soon as possible and ask about stopping or reversing it. A refund is not guaranteed.
- After a password or code was shared, contact the account provider and change exposed or reused passwords on a safe device. If someone controlled the device, disconnect it from the internet and get trusted help to remove remote access and check for malware.
- Keep messages, receipts, screenshots, and a short timeline. IdentityTheft.gov provides help for identity misuse, while ReportFraud.ftc.gov and IC3.gov accept scam reports. Avoid anyone asking for payment to recover the money.

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Scam warning checklist

For unexpected calls and messages

Use this checklist to review unexpected requests, and verify the source before acting even when none of these signs appears.

- ☐ Pressure to act now or stay on the phone
- ☐ Instructions to keep the request secret
- ☐ Threats of arrest or lost benefits
- ☐ An unexpected family emergency
- ☐ Gift cards, crypto, wires, or app payments
- ☐ Transfers to a “safe account”
- ☐ Requests for a password or sign-in code
- ☐ Requests for bank, Social Security, or Medicare details
- ☐ Device access or software installation
- ☐ Unexpected links, QR codes, or invoices

When something feels wrong

End the conversation without clicking, paying, sharing information, or installing software, then call someone you trust or the organization through a number you already know.

A common example

A caller claiming to be from your bank says your account is in danger and asks you to keep it secret while moving your money. The secrecy and transfer request are warning signs; end the call and contact the number on your bank card.

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My trusted contact plan

Who to call before sending money or sharing information

Complete this privately with someone you trust and keep it near your phone. Workshop staff should count completion without collecting this page.

Trusted contact _____ **Phone** _____

Backup contact _____ **Phone** _____

Bank or card provider _____ **Number from my card or statement** _____

Keep account numbers, PINs, and passwords off this page.

Our family emergency plan

Choose a private phrase together and keep it in a separate private place, away from cards you carry and workshop forms.

- ☐ We have chosen a phrase and practiced using it.
- ☐ We have saved known numbers for the people in our plan.

For an unexpected emergency, ask for the phrase without hints and call the relative at a saved number. If they cannot be reached, contact another relative before sending money, even if the phrase was correct.

A trusted friend, neighbor, caregiver, or staff member can also agree to help if family is not available.